

USION

The political colour of Parliament has changed. India is no longer wrapped in the tricolour of the Congress variety. It has over 20 shades, ranging from deep blue to red, saffron, green and yellow. Today, 37 parties are represented in Parliament—diversity can't get more Indian. Even in the Union Cabinet, regional parties have a majority representation, holding most of the key portfolios. From being a tricolour in the winds of power, the flag of democracy is a riot of colours—and they continue to multiply.

The change is overwhelming in the states as well. Smaller parties, born out of either caste or religion, are in power in most states. In the mid-'80s, there was hardly a state with a non-Congress leader in power. In 1982, the Congress

ruled in 20 of the 24 states. In 2007, it rules in 12 out of 29 states. The party is out of power in most big states except Andhra Pradesh; in Maharashtra and some north-eastern states, it is just a partner.

Therein lies another story of political mutation. The regional surge in political expression is directly proportional to the fading of India's Grand Old Party. While 27 parties were represented in the Lok Sabha in 1952, the purely regional ones accounted for just 16 seats as against the Congress's 339 in a House of 466. In the 2004 elections, the Congress got 151 seats and the 26 regional parties won 126 seats. When the Congress does well, regional parties perform badly. When Indira Gandhi made a spectacular comeback

in 1980 on the magic slogan of 'Vote for the Government that Governs', all the 17 local parties together got just 27 seats as against the Congress's 369. In 1984, the southern regional parties did exceptionally well even as the Congress, under Rajiv Gandhi, swept the entire north, west and east—though the real mandate was for the assassinated Mother India.

The vintage Congress was a political

26
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(From left to right) Shibu Soren, Farooq Abdullah, Naveen Patnaik, Mufti Mohammad Sayeed, Ram Vilas Paswan, Mulayam Singh Yadav, Parkash Singh Badal, Nitish Kumar, N. Chandrababu Naidu, Mamata Banerjee, Bal Thackeray, Sonia Gandhi, L.K. Advani, Mayawati, Bhajan Lal, K. Chandrasekhar Rao, Lalu Prasad Yadav, Om Prakash Chautala, H.D. Kumaraswamy, M. Karunanidhi, Vaiko, Anbumani Ramadoss, J. Jayalalitha

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